closing. By the time I was pulling on the jacket, lacing the smart shoes, sweat was running down my cheeks and back.

I'd always been sensitive to heat. Like Pa. He and I would joke about it. We're not made for this world, we said. Bloody snowmen. The dining room at Sandringham, for instance, was our version of Dante's *Inferno.* Much of Sandringham was balmy, but the dining room was subtropical. Pa and I would always wait for Granny to look away, then one of us would jump up, sprint to a window, crack it an inch. *Ah, blessed cool air.* But the corgis always betrayed us. The cool air would make them whimper, and Granny would say: *Is there a draft?* And then a footman would promptly shut the window. (That loud thump, unavoidable because the windows were so old, always felt like the door of a jail cell being slammed.) But now, every time I was about to make any kind of public appearance, no matter the venue, it felt like the Sandringham dining room. During one speech I became so overheated that I felt sure everyone was noticing and discussing it. During one drinks reception I searched frantically for anyone else who might be experiencing the same heatstroke. I needed some assurance that it wasn't just me.

But it was.

As is so often true of fear, mine metastasized. Soon it wasn't merely public appearances, but all public venues. All crowds. I came to fear simply being around other human beings.

More than anything else I feared cameras. I'd never liked cameras, of course, but now I couldn't abide them. The telltale click of a shutter opening and closing…it could knock me sideways for a whole day.

I had no choice: I began staying home. Day after day, night after night, I sat around eating takeaway, watching *24*. Or *Friends*. I think I might've watched every episode of *Friends* in 2013.

I decided I was a Chandler.

My *actual* friends would comment in passing that I didn't seem myself. As if I had flu. Sometimes I'd think, Maybe I'm *not* myself. Maybe that's what's going on here. Maybe this is some kind of metamorphosis. A new